

The Practitioner's Palette

What is actually inside the product, the actives worth knowing, and the cautions every kit deserves

Learning Objectives

- Explain what gives makeup its colour, and the difference between mineral and synthetic pigments
- Explain how SPF functions inside makeup, and its real-world limitations
- Identify common allergens and ethically relevant ingredients in cosmetics, including carmine
- Explain the specific risk of lead contamination in some traditional and low-cost kohl products

What gives makeup its colour

Colour in cosmetics comes primarily from two sources: mineral pigments such as iron oxides (reds, browns, yellows) and mica (the shimmer and light-reflecting base in most eyeshadows and highlighters), and synthetic organic pigments, lab-produced for shades minerals cannot achieve, particularly true blues, greens, and certain vivid pinks. Neither category is inherently superior — "mineral makeup" as a marketing term often implies a purity that a full ingredient list does not always support.

Film formers and the long-wear promise

"Long-wear" and "transfer-resistant" formulas rely on film-forming agents — typically silicones or specific polymers — that dry into a flexible, water-resistant layer over the skin. These formulas deliver genuinely longer wear, but they are also more occlusive and can be more difficult to remove without a dedicated dissolving cleanser, which matters directly to the barrier-health principles taught in Course I.

SPF inside makeup: real protection, real limits

Foundations and powders carrying an SPF rating do offer genuine protection, but almost never at the level a client assumes. Achieving a product's labelled SPF requires a far thicker, more even layer than most people apply as makeup — in practice, a light foundation application delivers a fraction of its labelled protection. Teach every client this plainly: makeup with SPF is a bonus layer, never a replacement for the dedicated sunscreen taught in Course I, applied first and allowed to set before makeup begins.

◆ Figure 4.1 · Two Pigment Families



Two pigment families, neither inherently "cleaner" than the other — judge formulas by full ingredient lists, not marketing category.

Allergens and ethically relevant ingredients

- **Fragrance** — the single most common trigger for cosmetic allergic reactions; fragrance-free options matter for sensitive clients.
- **Carmines (cochineal extract)**. A red pigment derived from crushed cochineal insects, used widely in lipsticks, blushes, and some eyeshadows. Not a safety concern for most users, but a real ethical and religious consideration — it is not vegan, and it is not acceptable within halal or kosher dietary frameworks that some clients extend to cosmetics applied near the mouth. List it plainly when asked; never assume a client's dietary framework from her appearance, and never treat the question as an inconvenience.
- **Nickel and certain preservatives** — occasional contact-allergy triggers worth knowing if a client reports a reaction history.

A specific, serious caution: lead in kohl

Traditional kohl and kajal, explored further in Module Five, carry real cultural weight — and a real, documented safety issue in some traditional and low-cost preparations: several studies have found dangerous levels of lead and other heavy metals in kohl products manufactured without regulatory oversight, particularly some sourced informally rather than from a regulated cosmetics manufacturer. This is not a reason to abandon the tradition. It is a reason to source only kohl and kajal tested and certified safe by a recognised cosmetics regulator, and to say so plainly to any client asking why your kit's version costs more than a market stall's.

Key Terms

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Practical Activity · The Ingredient Audit

Bring the ingredient list of one foundation and one lip product you use personally. Identify pigment type, presence of film-formers, SPF (if any), and check for carmine. Note whether the packaging discloses this clearly. **Bring your findings to your next live session.**